The Search for Signs of Intelligent Life in the Universe

By Jane Wagner and Lily Tomlin

TRUDY: Here we are, standing on the corner of "Walk don't walk." You look away from me, trying not to catch my eye, but you didn't turn fast enough, did you? You don't like my raspy voice, do you? I got this raspy voice 'cause I have to yell all the time 'cause nobody around here ever LISTENS to me.

You don't like that I scratch so much; yes. And excuse me, I scratch so much 'cause my neurons are on fire. And I admit my smile is not at its Pepsodent best 'cause I think my caps must've somehow got osteoperosis. And if my eyes seem to be twirling around like fruit flies, the better to see you with, my dears!

Look at me. You mammalian-brained LUNKHEADS! I'm not just talking to myself, I'm talking to you, too. And you And you And you And you and you and you!

INTRODUCTION

Searching for Signs of Intelligent Life in the Universe by Jane Wagner

TRUDY: I know what you're thinking, you're thinkin' that I'm crazy. You think I give a hoot? You people! Look at my shopping bags. Call me crazy, cause I save this junk. What should we call the ones who buy it?

It's my belief we all, at one time or another, secretly ask ourselves the question: Am I crazy.. In my case, the answer came back: A resounding YES!

In my case, the symptoms are subtle but unmistakable to the trained eye. For instance, here I am, standing at the corner of "Walk, Don't Walk." Waiting for these aliens from outer space

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to show up. I call that crazy, don't you? If I were sane, I should be waiting for the light like everybody else.

They're late . . . as usual. You'd think, as much as they know about time travel, they could be on time once in a while. I could kick myself. I told 'em I'd meet 'em on the corner of "Walk, Don't Walk" 'round lunchtime. Do they even know what "lunch" means? I doubt it. And "round" -- why did I say "round" Why wasn't I more specific?

Now they're probably stuck somewhere in time, wondering what I meant by "round lunchtime" And when they get here, they'll be dying to know what "lunchtime" means. And when they find out it means going to Howard Johnson's for fried clams, I wonder, will they be just a bit let down. I dread having to explain tarter sauce.

I know what you're thinking, you're thinkin' that I'm crazy. But frankly, goin' crazy was the best thing that ever happened to me. I don't say it's for everybody; some people couldn't cope. But for me it came at a time when nothing else seemed to be working. I got the kind of madness Socrates talked about, a divine release of the soul from the yoke of custom and convention. I refuse to be intimidated by reality anymore.

After all, what is reality anyway. Nothin' but a collective hunch. My space chums think reality was once a primitive method of crowd control that got out of hand. In my view, it's absurdity dressed up in a three-piece business suit. Reality is the leading cause of stress amongst those in touch with it. I can take it in small does, but as a lifestyle, I found it too confining. With all I have to do, I had to let something go.

Now, since I put reality on a back burner, my days are jam-packed and fun-filled. Some days, I go hand out around Seventh Avenue; I love to do this old joke: I wait for some music-loving tourist from one of the hotels on Central Park to go up and ask someone, "How do I get to Carnegie Hall." Then I run up and yell, "Practice!" The expression on people's faces is priceless. I never could've done stuff like that when I was in my right mind. I'd be worried people would think I was crazy.

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When I think of the fun I missed, I try not to be bitter. See, the human mind is kind of like a piñata. When it breaks open, there's a lot of surprises inside.

I was not always a bag lady, you know. I used to be a designer and creative consultant for big companies! Who do you think thought up the color scheme for Howard Johnson's? At the time, nobody was using orange and aqua together with fried clams.

Laugh tracks: I gave TV sitcoms the idea for canned laughter. I got the idea, one day I head voices and no one was there.

Who do you think had the idea to package panty hose in a plastic goose egg. One thing I personally don't like about panty hose, when you roll 'em down to the ankles the way I like 'em, you can't walk too good. People seem amused, so what's a little loss of dignity. You got to admit: It's a look!

The only idea I'm proud of -- my umbrella hat. Protects against sunstroke, rain, and muggers. For some reason, muggers steer clear of people wearing umbrella hats. So it should come as no shock. I am now creative consultant to these aliens from outer space. They're a kinda cosmic fact-finding committee. Amongst other projects, they've been searching all over for sign of intelligent life. It's a lot trickier than it sounds.

We're collecting all kinds of data about life here on Earth. We're determined to figure out, once and for all, just what the hell it all means. I write the data in these Post-its and then we study it. Don't worry, before I took the consulting job, I gave 'em my whole psychohistory. I told 'em what drove me crazy was my last creative consultant job with the Ritz Cracker mogul, Mr. Nabisco. It was my job to come up with snack inspirations to increase sales. I got this idea to give Cracker Consciousness to the entire planet.

I said, "Mr. Nabisco, sir! You could be the first to see the concept of munching to the third world. We got an untapped market here! These countries got million and millions of people don't even know where their next meal is coming from. So the idea of eatin' between meals is somethin' just never occurred to 'em!"

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Must've been when I went off the deep end. I woke up in the nuthouse. They were hookin' me up. One thing they don't tell you about shock treatments, for months afterwards you got flyaway hair. And it used to be my best feature. See, those shock treatments gave me new electrical circuitry (I think one of the doctors. hands must've been wet). I started having these time-space continuum shifts, I guess you'd call it. Suddenly, it was like my central nervous system had a patio addition out back. Not only do I have a linkup to extraterrestrial channels. I also got a hookup with humanity as a whole. Animals and plants, too. I used to talk to plants all the time; then, one day, they started talking back. They said, "Trudy, shut up!"

(mutters to herself for a moment, then peers at the sky) I told 'em I'd meet 'em on the corner of "Walk, Don't Walk." They're late . . . as usual. You'd think, as much as they know about time travel, they could be on time once in a while. *(mutters again and shuffles off)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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